GITHUB COPILOT DEV DAYS · OTTAWA

BILINGUAL BY DEFAULT

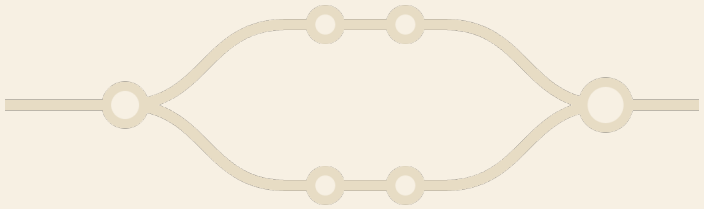
EN/FR parity enforced in the repo, with GitHub Copilot

Lilia Rowland

Principal AI Architect

LET'S CONNECT

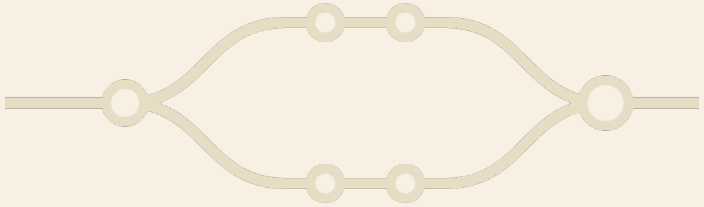
EN	Submit application	Upload a file	Save and continue later
FR	Soumettre la de…	Téléverser u…	Enregistrer et con…



A MOTTO FROM THE LAST DEV DAYS

DON'T ACCEPT THE DEFAULTS.

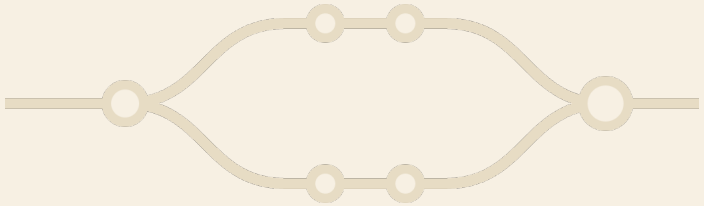
Make "both languages, same pull request" the default.



THE PROBLEM

Copilot is usually right.

"USUALLY" IS NOT A PROCESS.

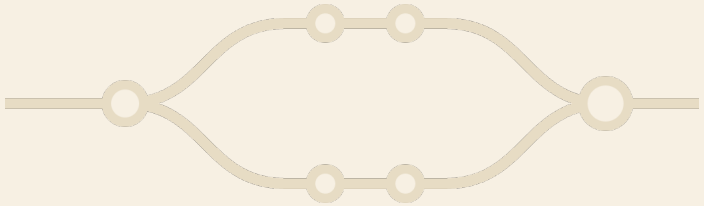


FROM MY REHEARSAL, NO SETUP

Copilot wrote « avant l'échéance ». Our glossary says « date limite ». Good French. Not *our* French.

WHAT GOES WRONG

SIX WAYS FRENCH BREAKS



Missing keys

English exists, French doesn't.

Terminology drift

courriel · e-mail · adresse électronique

Text expansion

French runs 15–30% longer.

Plurals

FR: 0 document
EN: 0 documents

Formatting

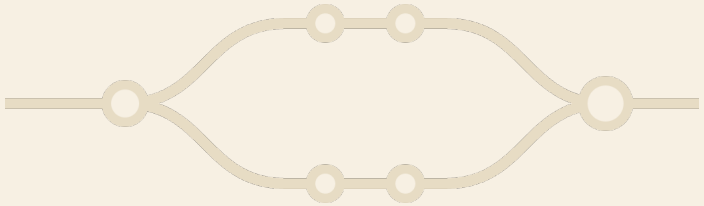
EN: $1,250.50
FR: 1 250,50 $

Typography

Total : 12 $
Prêt?

BEFORE ANYONE ASKS

WHAT EXISTS, AND WHAT THIS ADDS



Already exists

- Missing-key checkers
- Translation platforms: Crowdin, Lokalise
- AI skills for i18n

If you use them, keep them.

This talk adds

One human-owned glossary

⬇

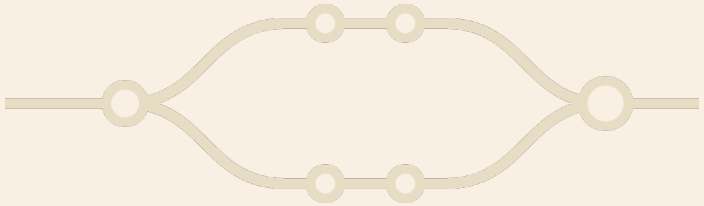
Read by the agent

⬇

Enforced by a required check

THE IDEA

THE PATTERN



Copilot writes

the code and the strings

The glossary decides

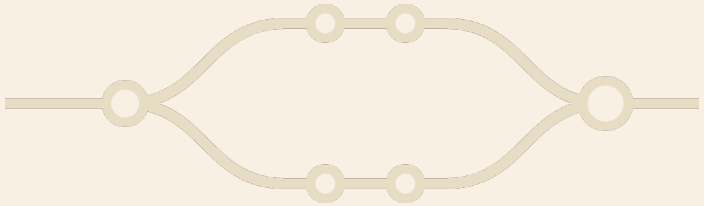
the words, owned by a translator

The pipeline enforces

the rules, with no AI in the loop

WHAT'S IN THE REPO

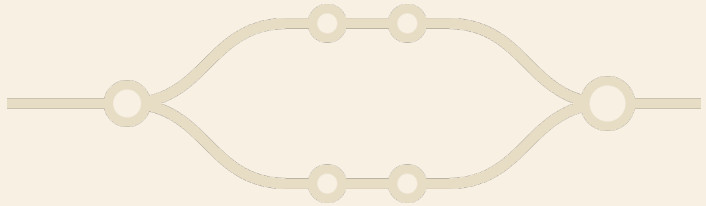
FOUR GUIDES AND ONE GATE



FILE	WHAT IT IS	WHEN IT'S USED
`copilot-instructions.md`	House rules	Always on
`locales.instructions.md`	Rules for language files	Only in locales/
`SKILL.md + glossary.csv`	French binder + glossary	Only when French is involved
`i18n-reviewer.agent.md`	Read-only reviewer	When you pick it
`i18n-parity.yml + check-parity.mjs`	**The gate, no AI**	**Every pull request**

THE DESIGN CHOICE

ONE GLOSSARY, TWO READERS



Copilot

reads it through the skill

glossary.csv

```
email → courriel
application → demande
benefit → prestation
```

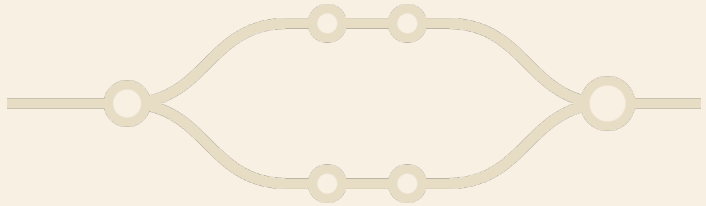
The check

reads the same file on every pull request

The reviewer suggests new terms → a translator adds them in a pull request

THE GATE

WHAT THE CHECK CATCHES



ERRORS · BLOCK THE MERGE

E1–E2	A key missing on either side
E3	{variables} don't match
E4	A French plural is missing a branch
E5	The approved term isn't used
E6	A term to avoid is used
E7	A message can't be parsed
E8	Text hardcoded in the HTML

WARNINGS · A PERSON DECIDES

W1	French identical to English
W2	French much longer on a button
W3	Canadian typography

DEMO

LET ME SHOW YOU

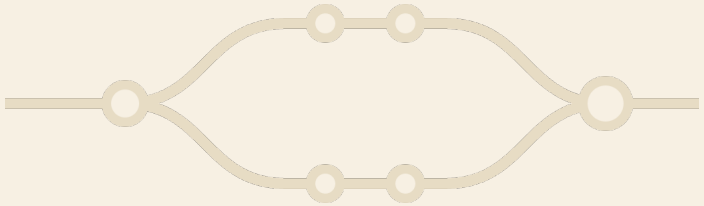
1 **No setup**
One request, no rules

2 **Set up**
Same request, word for word

3 **The gate**
Break the French, try to merge

BEFORE YOU ASK

QUESTIONS YOU'RE PROBABLY ASKING



Does this replace translators?

No. They own the glossary, and changes to it need their approval.

Can the agent change the rules?

Only by proposing it in a pull request. In production, add CODEOWNERS with required review.

Will it work with our stack?

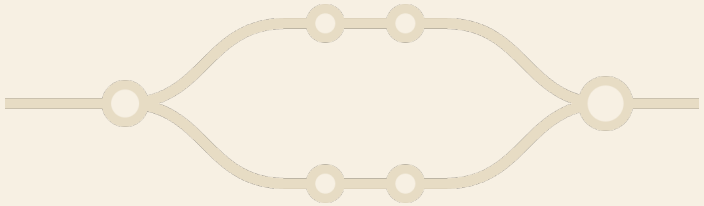
Swap the part that reads the files (.resx, i18next, .po). The idea stays the same.

Is this glossary official?

No, a small demo set. Yours comes from your translators and TERMIUM Plus.

TAKEAWAYS

THREE THINGS TO TAKE HOME



1. Copilot writes. The glossary decides. The pipeline enforces.
2. Put the rules where the agent and the pipeline both read them.
3. "Usually right" becomes "always checked".

TAKE IT HOME

YOUR RULES, IN YOUR REPO

github.com/LiliaAR/bilingual-by-default

Use this template · No dependencies
Runs in 30 seconds

THE REPO

LET'S CONNECT

Merci · Thank you